Contemporary Indian Society and Culture: Continuity and Change

UNIT- I

Introduction: Why Study Indian Society Sociologically?

India is one of the oldest continuous civilizations and, at the same time, one of the youngest modern nation-states. It is home to over 1.21 billion people (Census 2011), speaks hundreds of languages and dialects, follows all major world religions, and contains an extraordinary range of ethnic, regional, caste and tribal identities. Sociology helps us move beyond commonsense impressions and understand how these differences are organised, how they change and how they shape everyday life, work and politics.

This unit builds a foundation for the entire course. It answers three questions. First, what are the defining features of contemporary Indian society and culture? Second, how have external forces, namely the West (colonialism and modernity), Islam (medieval and later interactions) and globalization, influenced Indian society? Third, how do we understand the simultaneous presence of continuity (tradition) and change (modernity)? Sociologists such as M.N. Srinivas, Yogendra Singh, G.S. Ghurye, D.P. Mukerji and A.R. Desai gave important, and sometimes competing, answers to these questions.

Key terms to remember

Society: a system of social relationships that binds people together through shared institutions and norms.

Culture: the learned and shared way of life of a group, including values, beliefs, customs, language, arts and technology.

Tradition: practices and beliefs handed down across generations.

Modernity: a complex of rationality, secularism, individualism, science, technology and democratic ideals.

Social change: significant alteration in social structure and cultural patterns over time.

Features of Contemporary Indian Society and Culture

Unity in Diversity

The most widely cited feature of India is unity in diversity. Diversity exists in race, language, religion, caste, region, food, dress and custom. Unity, however, is provided by a shared civilizational heritage, pilgrimage networks, epics and folk traditions, a common history of anti-colonial struggle, and the constitutional framework after 1950. Jawaharlal Nehru described this in The Discovery of India as an ancient palimpsest on which layer upon layer of thought had been inscribed without hiding what lay beneath.

Sociologists caution that unity should not be taken for granted. It is a continuous political and cultural achievement, sustained through democratic institutions, federalism, linguistic reorganisation of states (1956 onwards), the Eighth Schedule recognition of languages, and constitutional guarantees to minorities.

Dimension of diversity	Illustration	Sociological significance
Linguistic	22 scheduled languages; Indo-Aryan, Dravidian, Austro-Asiatic and Tibeto-Burman families	Basis of state reorganisation and regional identity
Religious	Hindus, Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis and tribal faiths	Secularism as state principle; source of both syncretism and conflict
Caste and tribe	Thousands of jatis; over 700 notified Scheduled Tribes	Hierarchy, inequality and affirmative action
Regional and ecological	Himalayan, coastal, desert and plains societies	Different economies, kinship and customs
Cultural	Cuisine, festivals, dance, dress, architecture	Cultural capital, tourism and heritage industries

2. Caste as a Social Institution

Caste remains a central organising principle of Indian society. It refers to a system of hereditary, endogamous groups (jatis) ranked in a hierarchy based on notions of purity and pollution, with occupational specialisation. Louis Dumont (Homo Hierarchicus) saw hierarchy as the core ideology of caste, whereas Srinivas emphasised the role of the dominant caste and regional variation. Contemporary features include the decline of ritual restrictions on food and touch in public spaces, the persistence of endogamy in marriage, the growth of caste associations, and the politicisation of caste through reservation, electoral mobilisation and identity assertion.

3. Family, Kinship and Marriage

The joint family has long been regarded as the ideal Indian family form, but empirical studies (A.M. Shah, I.P. Desai) show that joint households coexist with nuclear ones and that many nuclear families remain functionally joint through property, ritual and emotional ties. Urbanisation, migration and education have increased nuclear and single-person households, dual-earner couples and love marriages, though arranged marriage still predominates and is now often mediated by matrimonial websites and apps. Patriarchy, patrilocal residence and patrilineal inheritance remain strong, and are gradually being contested by women's education and employment.

4. Religion and Religious Pluralism

India has been described as a civilization of many religions. Hinduism is itself a plural tradition without a single church or creed. Islam, Christianity, Sikhism, Buddhism and Jainism have deep roots. The constitutional model of secularism in India is not a strict separation of religion and state but principled equidistance and equal respect for all faiths (sarva dharma sambhava), with state intervention in religious institutions when needed for reform, as in temple entry and personal-law debates. Religion is publicly visible in festivals, media and politics, which is why sociologists study religiosity, revivalism and communalism side by side.

5. Village and Urban Society

Roughly two-thirds of Indians lived in rural areas in 2011 (urban share 31.16 per cent), and agriculture still employs a large section of the workforce. Yet India's cities are expanding rapidly through migration and census-town growth. The village, once romanticised as a self-sufficient "little republic" (Metcalfe, Marx), has been shown by Srinivas, Dube and Bailey to be a permeable unit linked to markets, states and networks. Rural society is being transformed by the Green Revolution, non-farm employment, mobile phones, remittances and welfare schemes such as MGNREGA and direct benefit transfers.

6. Demographic and Economic Features

- **Large and youthful population:** a majority of Indians are below 35, creating a potential demographic dividend that depends on education, health and job creation.
- **Literacy and sex ratio:** Census 2011 recorded literacy of 74.04 per cent and a sex ratio of 943 females per 1000 males, with wide gender and regional gaps.
- **Mixed economy and informal work:** a large informal sector, a fast-growing services sector and an expanding gig and platform economy.
- **Inequality:** persistent inequalities of caste, class, gender, region and religion alongside a growing middle class.

7. Democratic and Constitutional Framework

Independent India adopted parliamentary democracy, universal adult franchise, fundamental rights, Directive Principles and affirmative action. Democracy has enabled previously excluded groups, such as Dalits, Adivasis, OBCs and women, to claim voice, even though social inequality persists. The Constitution is best seen as a transformative document that seeks to change a hierarchical society into one of equality and dignity.

Features of Indian Culture

- **Syncretism and assimilation:** repeated absorption of Persian, Central Asian, Islamic, European and other influences.
- **Great and little traditions:** Sanskritic textual traditions coexist with regional oral and folk traditions (Robert Redfield, McKim Marriott).
- **Spiritual and philosophical richness:** dharma, karma, ahimsa and diverse schools of thought including Buddhism, Jainism, Bhakti and Sufism.
- **Family and community orientation:** collectivist values, respect for elders and obligations of kinship.
- **Vibrant popular culture:** Bollywood and regional cinema, cricket, television and social media form shared national culture.

Nature of Western Contact

Western influence entered India through Portuguese, Dutch, French and, above all, British colonial rule (1757 to 1947). The British impact was structural, not merely cultural: it changed land relations, law, administration, education, communication and the economy. Western influence also generated a reactive response from Indians in the form of reform movements, nationalism and cultural assertion.

Major Areas of Impact

Domain	Colonial / Western influence	Long-term effect
Economy and land	Permanent Settlement, Ryotwari and Mahalwari systems; commercialisation of agriculture; decline of handicrafts; railways	New landlord and peasant classes; agrarian distress; integrated national market
Law and administration	Codified civil and criminal law, uniform judiciary, bureaucracy, rule of law	Equality before law; modern legal-rational authority; Indian Penal Code legacy
Education	Macaulay's Minute (1835), English-medium schools, universities of 1857	Creation of the English-educated middle class and professional elite; also elitism and language divide

Domain	Colonial / Western influence	Long-term effect
Social reform	Introduction of liberal ideas; Abolition of Sati (1829), Widow Remarriage Act (1856), Age of Consent (1891)	Reform movements by Ram Mohan Roy, Vidyasagar, Phule, Ranade and others
Census and classification	Decennial census from 1871-72 enumerating caste and religion	Bernard Cohn and Nicholas Dirks argue that colonial classification hardened caste and religious identities
Communication and media	Railways, telegraph, postal service, printing press	Public sphere, newspapers, rise of national consciousness
Political ideas	Liberalism, nationalism, democracy, socialism	Anti-colonial movement and constitutional democracy

Westernization (M.N. Srinivas)

Srinivas defined **Westernization** as the changes brought about in Indian society and culture as a result of over 150 years of British rule, covering changes at different levels: technology, institutions, ideology and values. He distinguished it from Sanskritization, in which a lower caste emulates the ritual and lifestyle of higher castes. Westernization manifests in dress, food, sports, building styles, the use of English and the adoption of humanitarianism, equality and rationalism. He noted that Westernization occurred in different subtypes: a small section adopted Western lifestyle and thinking deeply (the elite), while a much larger section adopted only external cultural traits.

Criticism: the concept is descriptive, overlaps with modernization, and may underplay the way Indians selectively adapted and resisted Western ideas. Yogendra Singh argued that the term should be seen as one channel of modernization, alongside others such as the democratic system and industrialization.

Modernization of Indian Tradition (Yogendra Singh)

Yogendra Singh (Modernization of Indian Tradition, 1973) proposed that India's modernization should be studied as a process of structural and cultural change rather than as simple imitation of the West. He identified two processes, **universalization** and **parochialization** (drawing on McKim Marriott), and highlighted how tradition itself adapts to modern conditions. Modernization affected the family, education, occupation and political consciousness, but selectively and unevenly, so that traditional and modern elements often coexist.

Orientalism and Indology

Colonial scholars such as William Jones and Max Muller produced knowledge about Indian texts, and this knowledge shaped the colonial view of India as a land of caste, village and religion. Edward Said's Orientalism (1978) critiqued such knowledge as tied to power. Sociologists of India remain concerned with how Indian society is represented and by whom, which connects to the debates on indigenization in Unit II.

Influence of Islam on Indian Society

Historical Background

Islam arrived in India through Arab traders on the Malabar coast in the seventh century, and later through Turkic, Afghan and Mughal rule (from the twelfth to the eighteenth century). Over centuries, Islam became an integral part of Indian society. India today has one of the largest Muslim populations in the world (14.2 per cent of the population in Census 2011), spread across all regions and classes. The interaction between Indian society and Islam was not one-directional: Islam also became Indianized.

Areas of Influence

- **Language and literature:** the emergence of Urdu, Persian influence on administration and poetry, and the enrichment of regional languages with Persian and Arabic words.
- **Art and architecture:** the Indo-Islamic style, including the Qutub Minar, Fatehpur Sikri, the Taj Mahal, and Mughal miniature painting.
- **Music and performing arts:** the Hindustani classical tradition, qawwali, ghazal and the contributions of Amir Khusrau and Tansen.
- **Cuisine, dress and etiquette:** Mughlai cuisine, sherwani, salwar-kameez and the tehzeeb of courtly manners.
- **Administration and economy:** the revenue system (Sher Shah and Akbar's Todar Mal), coinage, postal and road networks and urban centres.
- **Religion and philosophy:** the Bhakti and Sufi movements shared emphasis on devotion, equality and inner experience.

Sufism and Bhakti: Syncretism

Sufi orders (Chishti, Suhrawardi, Qadiri, Naqshbandi) and Bhakti saints (Kabir, Nanak, Chaitanya, Mirabai, Tukaram) preached love, service and humanism, and questioned rigid ritualism and caste. Kabir and Guru Nanak are especially associated with a synthesis of Hindu and Muslim thought. Shared shrines (dargahs), festivals and pilgrimage sites continue to reflect a composite culture, often called Ganga-Jamuni tehzeeb.

Social Stratification among Muslims

Sociologists such as Imtiaz Ahmad (Caste and Social Stratification among Muslims in India, 1973) showed that hierarchy exists among Indian Muslims. They are traditionally divided into

Ashraf (claiming foreign descent or high status: Sayyid, Sheikh, Mughal, Pathan), **Ajlaf** (converts from clean occupational castes) and **Arzal** (converts from the lowest castes). Groups such as the Pasmanda Muslims continue to demand recognition of their backwardness. This demonstrates how caste logic influences other religious communities in India.

Contemporary Concerns

The Sachar Committee Report (2006) documented the relative educational and economic backwardness of Muslims. Debates on Muslim personal law, representation, communal violence and identity politics remain important in contemporary India (see Unit IV). A sociologically balanced view avoids essentialising communities and instead studies the diversity of Muslim experience across region, class, sect and gender.

Influence of Globalization on Indian Society

What is Globalization?

Globalization is the intensification of worldwide social relations linking distant localities so that local events are shaped by events occurring many miles away (Anthony Giddens). It has economic, political, technological and cultural dimensions. Arjun Appadurai (Modernity at Large) described global cultural flows as five "scapes": ethnoscapes, technoscapes, finances capes, mediascapes and ideoscapes. Roland Robertson coined **glocalization** to explain how global forms are adapted to local contexts. George Ritzer's **McDonaldization** thesis describes the spread of efficiency, calculability and predictability.

The Indian Context: 1991 and After

India's economic reforms of 1991 (liberalization, privatization and globalization, or LPG) opened the economy to foreign capital, trade and technology. Since then, the country has seen the growth of the IT and IT-enabled services sector, business process outsourcing, telecom and digital payments (UPI), expansion of private higher education, malls and organised retail, and large-scale migration and diaspora connections.

Impact on Different Spheres

Sphere	Positive impact	Concerns and criticisms
Economy and work	Growth, new jobs in IT, services, startups; rising incomes and consumer choice	Informalisation and contractualisation; jobless growth; widening inequality; agrarian distress
Culture	Exchange of ideas, cuisine, music, cinema; global recognition of yoga and Indian arts	Cultural homogenisation; consumerism; commodification of tradition

Sphere	Positive impact	Concerns and criticisms
Family and gender	Greater educational and job options for women; changing marriage patterns	Work-life strain; new forms of violence and cyber-harassment; persistent wage gaps
Media and technology	Internet, social media, digital inclusion, e-governance	Digital divide; misinformation; surveillance and privacy issues
Class and consumption	Growth of the new middle class and aspirational consumption	Status anxiety; debt; environmental costs
Politics and identity	Global human rights and social movements; transnational networks	Rise of identity assertion, sometimes reactive or fundamentalist; weakening of the welfare state
Language	English as a skill for global employability	Marginalisation of regional languages and their speakers

Diaspora and Transnationalism

The Indian diaspora, estimated at over 30 million people, contributes remittances, knowledge networks and cultural exchange. Returning migrants and transnational families bring new ideas to Indian society. Sociologists use the concept of transnationalism to study how migrants live across borders while maintaining ties to family, caste and religious networks.

Understanding the Concepts

Continuity refers to persistence of institutions, values and practices. Change refers to their transformation. Indian society displays both simultaneously. Milton Singer's work on Madras showed that industrialists and professionals used modern means (cars, telephones) while continuing traditional rituals, a pattern he called **compartmentalization** and **traditionalization of modernity** rather than the simple replacement of tradition by modernity.

Processes of Cultural Change in India

Concept	Thinker	Meaning	Example
Sanskritization	M.N. Srinivas	Lower castes adopt customs, rituals and beliefs of higher (twice-born) castes to improve status	Adopting vegetarianism, wearing the sacred thread

Concept	Thinker	Meaning	Example
Westernization	M.N. Srinivas	Change due to British rule at level of technology, institutions, ideology	English education, Western dress, sports like cricket
Modernization	Yogendra Singh, Daniel Lerner	Broad change towards rational, secular, industrial society	Professional occupation, democratic participation
Universalization and Parochialization	McKim Marriott	Local traditions elevated to Great Tradition and Great Tradition localised	Local goddess merged into pan-Indian Devi
Secularization	M.N. Srinivas	Decline of religious control over social life	Reduced ritual restrictions in public dining
De-Sanskritization / Resistance	Dalit and anti-caste movements	Rejection of upper-caste norms and assertion of independent identity	Ambedkarite Buddhism, Dalit literature

Areas of Continuity

- Caste as a marker of identity, marriage and politics.
- Family and kinship networks, including obligations to elders.
- Religious belief and ritual life; festivals such as Diwali, Eid, Christmas and Pongal.
- Patriarchy and gendered division of labour, though under challenge.
- Rural social structures and agrarian relations in many regions.

Areas of Change

- Occupational diversification and mobility beyond caste-based jobs.
- Expansion of education, especially for girls; rise of the middle class.
- Rise of nuclear and dual-career families; changing marriage practices.
- Political participation of Dalits, OBCs, women and minorities.
- Urbanisation, migration and technological change (mobile, internet).

Major Sociological Perspectives

- **G.S. Ghurye** (Indological or cultural approach) emphasised continuity of civilizational traditions and the historical role of caste and kinship.
- **D.P. Mukerji** argued that sociologists must study Indian tradition, and that it has an inbuilt capacity for change through Sufism, Bhakti and the emphasis on experience, while Western concepts should be used carefully.
- **A.R. Desai** (Marxist approach) analysed how colonial capitalism transformed Indian society and how nationalism reflected the rising bourgeois class.
- **Yogendra Singh** developed a structural-cultural approach to modernization of tradition.
- **M.N. Srinivas** (structural-functional and fieldwork tradition) studied village and caste through concepts of Sanskritization, Westernization and dominant caste.
- **Louis Dumont** considered India as fundamentally different from the West because of hierarchy (homo hierarchicus) as opposed to egalitarian individualism (homo aequalis).

Exam tip: linking continuity and change

A good answer avoids a simple "tradition versus modernity" binary.
Show that
(a) tradition changes,
(b) modernity is filtered through tradition, and
(c) there is uneven change across caste, class, gender and region.

Skill Development and Employability Dimensions

Study of Indian society is not only theoretical. The concepts in this unit build transferable skills valued by employers in public policy, civil services, education, NGOs, development consulting, market research, media, human resources and corporate social responsibility.

Skill	How this unit develops it	Where it is useful
Cultural competence and diversity management	Understanding caste, religion, language and regional diversity and avoiding stereotypes	HR, teaching, healthcare, hospitality, marketing, public service
Critical and analytical thinking	Evaluating concepts like Sanskritization, Westernization and globalization, and questioning binary views	Research, policy analysis, journalism, civil services examinations
Research and fieldwork skills	Village studies, interviews, observation, case-study writing	Social research organisations, NGOs, market and survey agencies
Communication and writing	Structured essays, presentations, summarising debates	Media, content, communications, consulting
Intercultural and global awareness	Understanding diaspora, transnational networks and global culture	International organisations, multinational companies, tourism
Data literacy	Reading Census, NFHS and NSSO data on demography, literacy, sex ratio and employment	Development sector, government, data analytics
Ethics and social sensitivity	Awareness of inequality, discrimination and inclusion	CSR, social work, legal aid, community development

UNIT-I

LONG QUESTIONS

1. Discuss the major features of contemporary Indian society and culture. Explain how unity in diversity, caste, family, religion, rural–urban society and the democratic framework shape contemporary India.

2. Critically examine the impact of Western contact and colonial rule on Indian society and culture. Discuss its effects on the economy, land relations, law, administration, education, social reform, communication and political ideas.

3. Explain M.N. Srinivas's concept of Westernization. How is Westernization different from Sanskritization? Critically evaluate the relevance and limitations of the concept in understanding contemporary Indian society.

4. Examine the influence of Islam on Indian society and culture. Discuss its contributions to language, literature, architecture, music, cuisine, administration, religion and the development of a composite culture.

5. Discuss the impact of globalization on Indian society after the economic reforms of 1991. Critically analyse its effects on economy, work, family, gender, culture, media, consumption, language and identity.

UNIT II

Current Debates: Contextualization, Indigenization and Sociology for India

Introduction: The Question of How to Study India

Sociology as a discipline emerged in nineteenth-century Europe to understand industrialization, urbanization and the decline of traditional authority. Its founding concepts, such as class, bureaucracy, secularization, individualism and the nation-state, were shaped by European experience. When the discipline came to India through colonial administrators, missionaries, Orientalist scholars and later university departments (Bombay from 1919, Calcutta, Lucknow), a basic question arose: can concepts developed in the West adequately explain Indian society, or must Indian sociology develop its own concepts, methods and concerns?

This question has produced some of the richest debates in Indian sociology. Scholars have asked whether we should apply Western categories directly, adapt them to Indian conditions (contextualization), build theory from within Indian traditions (indigenization), use categories native to Indian thought (such as varna, jati, dharma, karma) in analysis, read Indian texts alongside fieldwork (text and context), and ultimately develop a sociology that serves the people of India (sociology for India).

Background: Development of Sociology in India

Phases of Development

Phase	Period	Features
Colonial and early phase	Late 19th century to 1947	Orientalist and administrative ethnography (Risley, Hutton, Senart, Max Muller, Henry Maine); missionary writings; census and gazetteers; Indian pioneers such as G.S. Ghurye, Radhakamal Mukerjee, D.P. Mukerji, and Patrick Geddes at Bombay
Post-independence consolidation	1950s to 1960s	Village studies (Srinivas, S.C. Dube, McKim Marriott, Andre Beteille); structural-functionalism; influence of British social anthropology and American sociology; Nehruvian focus on nation-building and development

Phase	Period	Features
Critical and reflexive phase	1970s onwards	Marxist, subaltern, feminist and Dalit perspectives; debates about indigenization, colonial knowledge and relevance; Contributions to Indian Sociology (1957, Dumont and Pocock) as an important forum
Contemporary phase	1990s to present	Globalization, identity, gender, environment, technology, new social movements; interdisciplinary and comparative approaches; public sociology

The Colonial Legacy in Knowledge

Colonial ethnography described India as a land of caste, village and religion. The Census of India and works like H.H. Risley's The Tribes and Castes of Bengal created classifications that treated caste as a rigid, all-India system. Bernard Cohn and Ronald Inden argue that such knowledge was intertwined with colonial power. This raises the question of whether the categories that Indian sociology inherited are neutral and prompts the call for indigenization and a critical reading of tradition.

Contextualization

Meaning

Contextualization means locating sociological concepts, theories and research questions in their specific historical, cultural and social settings. Rather than mechanically applying theories such as Marx's class analysis, Weber's bureaucracy or Durkheim's solidarity to India, scholars examine how these theories must be modified to account for caste, religion, kinship, colonialism and regional variation. Contextualization does not reject universal concepts; it insists on testing them against context.

Contextualization in Method

It also applies to research methods. Survey questions, concepts of household, work, marriage or education, and even translation of terms need to be adapted. For example, categories such as "employed" or "household" may miss informal, seasonal, women's or unpaid work when applied without sensitivity to the Indian context. Good research therefore involves contextual pilot testing, local-language tools and participatory approaches.

Indigenization

Meaning and Rationale

Indigenization refers to the process of developing sociological concepts, theories and methods rooted in the cultural and intellectual traditions of a society, in place of wholesale borrowing

from the West. In India, it means drawing on Indian philosophical and social thought, indigenous categories and regional experiences to build a distinctive sociology. Scholars use the term in several senses.

- **Indigenization as decolonization of knowledge:** breaking the dependency on Western theoretical frameworks and the "academic colonialism" where Indian data feeds Western theory.
- **Indigenization as relevance:** orienting research to Indian problems such as caste, poverty, agrarian distress, tribal displacement and gender discrimination.
- **Indigenization as use of native categories:** employing concepts like varna, jati, dharma, karma, ashrama and purusartha as analytical tools.
- **Indigenization as institutional change:** teaching in Indian languages, supporting Indian journals and publishers, and training scholars in Indian intellectual traditions.

Major Contributors

Scholar	Contribution / position
G.S. Ghurye	Indological approach; used ancient texts and history to study caste, kinship, tribe and religion; stressed civilizational continuity. Founded Bombay School of Sociology.
Radhakamal Mukerjee	Drew on Indian philosophy and values; ecological and civilizational approach; comparative study of social structures and values.
D.P. Mukerji	Advocated study of Indian tradition (sruti, smriti, anubhava, the concept of experience), and combined Marxism with attention to tradition; argued for a sociologist to be an Indian first, sociologist next.
A.K. Saran	Strong critic of Western positivism; argued for grounding Indian sociology in Hindu (dharmic) categories and thought; critiqued the concept of "Indian society" as constructed by Western social science.
Louis Dumont	Foreign scholar who argued that Indian society must be understood through its own ideology of hierarchy (purity and pollution) rather than Western egalitarianism. Founded Contributions to Indian Sociology with David Pocock.
T.N. Madan	Argued for sociology "of" India as engaged, reflexive and tied to Indian traditions of thought; wrote about secularism, religion and the Hindu householder.
Yogendra Singh	Called for the indigenization of Indian sociology in the sense of relevance and non-dependence, while remaining open to a global social science.

Scholar	Contribution / position
Ashis Nandy, Veena Das, Dipankar Gupta	Different critical voices: Nandy on colonialism of the mind; Das on suffering, texts and everyday life; Gupta on contemporary structures and critique of "culturalist" accounts of caste.

Critiques and Cautions

- Overemphasis on indigenization may lead to cultural essentialism, where "Indian" is defined narrowly, often through Sanskritic or upper-caste Hindu traditions and neglecting Dalit, tribal, Muslim, regional and women's voices.
- Sociology is a comparative discipline and hence must be in dialogue with global scholarship. Complete isolation may weaken standards and comparability.
- Indigenization may be misused politically as nationalist ideology.
- The best approach is critical: selectively use both Western and native concepts and test them against evidence.

Sociology for India

Meaning

"Sociology for India" asks for whom sociology is being produced and what purpose it serves. It stresses that the discipline in India should address Indian social problems, contribute to policy and social transformation, and be accountable to the people whose lives it studies. Yogendra Singh, D.P. Mukerji, A.R. Desai and Andre Beteille each contributed to thinking on this issue. It is related to, but different from, "sociology of India," which describes and analyses Indian society academically.

Themes and Priorities

- **Inequality and social justice:** caste, class, gender, tribe, disability and religion-based exclusion.
- **Development and displacement:** dams, mining, land acquisition, forest rights and livelihood.
- **Agrarian and labour issues:** agrarian distress, migration, informal work, gig economy.
- **Health, education and welfare:** access, quality, gender gaps, digital divide.
- **Democracy and politics:** identity politics, caste and elections, communalism, citizenship and rights.
- **Environment and technology:** climate vulnerability, urban pollution, AI and digital society.

Perspectives on the Role of Sociology

Perspective	Representative	Idea
Value-neutral academic	Andre Beteille, M.N. Srinivas	Sociology should follow scientific standards and avoid becoming ideology, but can inform policy
Engaged / critical	A.R. Desai, D.P. Mukerji	Sociology should critique inequality and contribute to social transformation
Subaltern and Dalit	B.R. Ambedkar, Gopal Guru, Sharmila Rege	Knowledge must be grounded in the experience of the oppressed; the "who speaks" question matters (theoretical Brahmins versus empirical Shudras debate)
Feminist	Leela Dube, Maitrayee Chaudhuri, Uma Chakravarti	Gender must be central; research must include women's experience
Public sociology	Michael Burawoy (global), Indian scholars in media and policy	Sociology should communicate with public audiences and engage in social debate

The Dalit and Feminist Challenge

Gopal Guru's argument that Indian social science often treats Dalits as objects of study rather than theorists challenges the "sociology of India" from within. Sharmila Rege's "Dalit feminist standpoint" shows how caste and gender together shape knowledge. These critiques broaden the scope of indigenization by insisting that "native" does not mean only Brahmanical or elite traditions but includes the voices of Bahujans, women, tribes and minorities.

Skill Development and Employability Dimensions

The debates in this unit train students in reasoning, argumentation and ethical reflection. They also prepare graduates to work in contexts where cultural sensitivity and methodological judgement are essential.

Skill	How the unit develops it	Career relevance
Critical thinking and argumentation	Evaluating competing views (book vs field; indigenization vs universalism)	Civil services, law, policy analysis, journalism, academia
Research design and methodology	Choosing appropriate concepts, contextual tools and mixed methods	Research institutes, NGOs, survey and evaluation agencies, data analytics
Cross-cultural communication	Working with emic and etic categories; translation of concepts	International development, market research, UX and user research
Reflexivity and ethics	Awareness of positionality, power and representation in research	Community development, social work, human rights
Policy and advocacy skills	Linking sociological knowledge to Indian social problems	Government, think tanks, CSR, public health and education programmes
Writing and public engagement	Constructing reasoned essays, op-eds and presentations	Media, publishing, communications

UNIT-II

LONG QUESTIONS

1. What is contextualization in sociology? Discuss its significance for studying Indian society and explain why Western sociological concepts may require modification according to Indian social and cultural conditions.

2. Critically examine the concept of indigenization of Indian sociology. Discuss its meaning, objectives, major dimensions and the arguments in favour of developing sociological concepts rooted in Indian intellectual traditions.

3. Discuss the contributions of G.S. Ghurye, Radhakamal Mukerjee, D.P. Mukerji, A.K. Saran, T.N. Madan and Yogendra Singh to the development and indigenization of Indian sociology.

4. Explain the colonial legacy in the development of sociological knowledge about India. How did colonial ethnography, census and administrative classifications influence the understanding of caste, tribe, religion and Indian society?

5. What is meant by "Sociology for India"? Discuss its objectives and explain how sociology can contribute to social justice, development, democracy, welfare, environmental concerns and social transformation in India.

UNIT- III

Class Structure in India, the Middle Class, the New Elite, and Identity Assertions

Introduction: Class in a Caste Society

Social stratification in India has long been explained through caste, but class, defined by one's relationship to the means of production, income, occupation and life chances, has been equally important, especially since colonial rule introduced new land, labour and market relations. In contemporary India, caste, class, gender, religion, region and ethnicity intersect. A Dalit professor and a Dalit landless labourer share a caste label but differ in class position; a Brahmin priest and a Brahmin executive have different economic standing. Sociologists therefore study **how class is formed, how it relates to caste and how new groups (middle class, elites, ethnic communities) assert themselves.**

Class Structure in India: Agrarian Pre-Colonial and Colonial Background

Before colonial rule, land rights were layered, involving rulers, intermediaries and cultivators with customary rights. The British introduced the Permanent Settlement (Zamindari) in Bengal (1793), Ryotwari in Madras and Bombay and Mahalwari in parts of north India. These systems converted land into private property, fixed revenue demands and encouraged commercialisation of agriculture. The results were the rise of landlords and moneylenders, indebtedness and insecurity among peasants, and growth of landless labour. A.R. Desai argued that colonialism destroyed the old rural economy and created a new class structure serving imperial interests.

Post-Independence Agrarian Structure

After 1947, India passed land reforms: abolition of zamindari and other intermediaries, tenancy regulation, land ceiling laws and consolidation of holdings. Their implementation was uneven. Abolition of intermediaries largely succeeded in ending absentee landlordism, but ceiling and tenancy laws were weakly enforced except in states such as West Bengal (Operation Barga) and Kerala. The **Green Revolution** (from the mid-1960s in Punjab, Haryana and western Uttar Pradesh, later elsewhere) increased productivity but favoured farmers with land, capital and irrigation, widening regional and class disparities.

Classes in Agrarian India

Class	Description	Characteristics
Landlords and large farmers	Owners of large holdings, often absentee or capitalist farmers	Employ wage labour, commercial farming, links with politics and markets; often dominant castes
Rich / middle peasants	Owner-cultivators with surplus, using family and hired labour	Beneficiaries of Green Revolution; became politically powerful (e.g.,

Class	Description	Characteristics
		Jats, Patels, Reddys, Kammas, Vokkaligas, Marathas)
Small and marginal farmers	Holdings too small for subsistence	Indebtedness; supplementary wage work; majority of operational holdings
Tenants and sharecroppers	Cultivate leased land	Insecure rights, often informal tenancy
Agricultural labourers	Landless or near-landless wage workers	Often Dalits and Adivasis; low wages, seasonal migration, bonded labour in some regions
Rural non-farm classes	Artisans, traders, service providers, rural professionals	Growing importance with diversification of the rural economy

Sociological Perspectives on Agrarien Classes

- **Daniel Thorner:** proposed a three-fold division, **malik** (landowners who do not cultivate), **kisan** (cultivating owners) and **mazdoor** (labourers), based on income from land, and rights and obligations.
- **A.R. Desai:** analysed rural society in terms of colonial and capitalist transformation; the peasant movements as class struggles.
- **Andre Beteille:** in Caste, Class and Power studied Sripuram, showing how distribution of power moved from caste-based to a more class-based and political pattern, with the three hierarchies of class, status and power not always coinciding.
- **Mode of production debate (1970s):** Scholars such as Utsa Patnaik, Ashok Rudra and Hamza Alavi debated whether Indian agriculture was semi-feudal or capitalist; Jairus Banaji and others emphasised varied forms of capitalist transition.
- **Ghanshyam Shah, Gail Omvedt:** studied peasant and Dalit movements, showing overlap between caste and class oppression in agrarian India.

2.4 Caste-Class Overlap and Change

In many regions, upper and dominant castes still control land, while Dalits form the bulk of agricultural labour. But there have been significant shifts: the decline of traditional jajmani relations, growing wage labour, migration to cities, the rise of intermediate (OBC) castes as agrarian and political powers, and increasing non-farm employment. Agrarian distress, indebtedness, farmers' suicides, price volatility and the farmers' protests of 2020-21 show the continuing importance of agrarian class issues.

Class Structure in India: Industrial Origins and Growth

Modern industry began in colonial India with cotton mills in Bombay (1850s), jute mills in Calcutta, railways, coal mining and plantations. Colonial policy favoured British interests and constrained indigenous industry, though Indian entrepreneurs (Tata, Birla, Bajaj, Walchand Hirachand) emerged, often connected to the nationalist movement. After 1947, planned development through Five-Year Plans emphasised heavy industry, a large public sector and import substitution under a "licence-permit" regime. The 1991 liberalisation shifted the emphasis to markets, private capital and services.

Industrial Classes

Class	Features
Industrial capitalists / business families	Large corporate houses, traditionally from trading communities (Marwaris, Gujaratis, Parsis, Chettiars) and now including new entrepreneurs, IT founders and startup owners; strong links with the state and global capital
Managerial and professional class	Corporate executives, engineers, bankers, consultants; educational credentials and skills; part of the new middle class
Petty bourgeoisie / small business	Shopkeepers, small manufacturers, traders, transport operators; self-employed
Organised working class	Workers in factories, public sector units and large firms with formal contracts, unions and social security; a small share of the total workforce
Unorganised / informal workers	Construction workers, street vendors, domestic workers, home-based workers, contract and casual labour; roughly 90 per cent of India's workforce; low income, insecurity and no social protection
Gig and platform workers	Delivery, ride-hailing and app-based workers; flexible but insecure work with algorithmic management

Key Features and Issues

- **Informalisation and contractualization:** shrinking of permanent factory jobs and growth of casual, contract and outsourced labour (Jan Breman studied "footloose labour" in western India).
- **Trade unions and labour movement:** early leaders included N.M. Lokhande and S.A. Dange; unions like AITUC, INTUC and CITU; the 1974 railway strike; the decline of union power in the era of liberalisation. New labour codes are a live policy debate.
- **Caste and gender in industry:** recruitment through caste and kin networks (Morris D. Morris, Ramaswamy); Dalit and Muslim workers concentrated in low-paid, hazardous jobs; women's work concentrated in the informal sector, care work and specific industries such as garments.

- **Migration and urbanisation:** circular migrants, slum settlements and "footloose" labour form a large working class.
- **Regional unevenness:** industrial growth is concentrated in western and southern states; the east and centre lag behind.

Relationship between Agrarian and Industrial Classes

Agrarian and industrial classes are linked. Rural households diversify into non-farm work; migrants belong simultaneously to village and city; agricultural surplus, land and labour markets are tied to industry and services. Some scholars, such as Pranab Bardhan, describe India's political economy as dominated by **three proprietary classes**: industrial capitalists, rich farmers and professionals (including bureaucrats), who compete for state resources and influence public policy.

Emergence and Role of the Middle Class in India

Meaning and Debates

The Indian middle class is not a single, homogeneous class. Definitions vary: by income and consumption (e.g., NCAER and World Bank measures), by occupation (professionals, clerical and managerial workers, small business), by education and cultural capital (English education, urban lifestyle) or by aspirations and values. Scholars therefore speak of the "middle classes" in the plural.

Historical Emergence

- **Colonial origins:** The colonial state created a class of English-educated Indians (lawyers, teachers, clerks, doctors, journalists) trained by Western-style schools and colleges. This class, often from upper castes such as Brahmins, Kayasthas, Banias and Chitpavans, led social reform and the nationalist movement (Bipan Chandra, Sudipta Kaviraj).
- **Post-independence "old" middle class:** salaried employees in government, public sector, teaching and professions, benefiting from state-led development, reservation-free "merit" and public education, and shaping Nehruvian values of secularism, science and planning.
- **Post-1991 "new" middle class:** growth linked to liberalisation, private sector employment (IT, finance, media, consulting), consumer culture, malls, credit and global mobility (Leela Fernandes, Pavan K. Varma, Rajni Kothari).
- **Emerging "neo-middle class":** first-generation aspirants from small towns, OBC, Dalit and rural backgrounds who enter education, jobs and businesses; their upward mobility is fragile and depends on education, remittances and networks.

Characteristics

Old middle class	New middle class
Public-sector and government jobs; job security	Private-sector, global and service-sector jobs; contractual and performance-based
Values of thrift, saving, austerity and public service	Consumerism, credit, aspiration, lifestyle and brands
Attachment to the Nehruvian state and public institutions	Market orientation; reliance on private education, healthcare and housing
Relatively homogeneous in caste (upper-caste, Hindu)	More diverse but still dominated by upper castes; growing OBC/Dalit entrants
Regional language and local networks	English, global exposure, digital media

Role of the Middle Class

- **Social reform and nationalism:** leadership of reform movements and the freedom struggle.
- **Democracy and civil society:** participation in campaigns such as the anti-corruption movement (2011), RTI activism, environmental and urban resident associations.
- **Economic role:** major driver of consumption, savings, housing and services; supplier of skilled labour and entrepreneurship.
- **Cultural role:** diffusion of new lifestyles, media consumption, education and gender norms; influence on popular culture.
- **Political role:** middle-class voting, opinion-making and support for policies of growth, and sometimes for religious nationalism.
- **Contradictions:** the middle class is criticised for withdrawing from public services (gated communities, private schools), being indifferent to poverty, or resisting reservation, while also being praised as the carrier of civic values.

Key thinkers on the middle class

Pavan K. Varma (The Great Indian Middle Class, 1998): traces its colonial roots and criticises its conservatism and consumerism.

Leela Fernandes (India's New Middle Class, 2006): sees it as a political and cultural project of liberalisation.

Satish Deshpande: argues that the middle class is heavily upper caste in composition and functions as the "model" citizen in national imagination.

Sanjay Joshi, Amita Baviskar, Rajni Kothari: examine the civic and political roles of middle-class groups.

. The New Indian Elite

Meaning of Elite

An elite is a minority that holds a disproportionate share of power, wealth, prestige or influence. Pareto spoke of "circulation of elites", Mosca of the "ruling class", and C. Wright Mills of the "power elite". In India, elites have historically been from upper castes (priestly, warrior, landholding and scribal groups) and later from English-educated professionals and industrial families. Andre Beteille has noted that in India, elites are recruited from different social bases and are less a closed ruling class than a set of overlapping groups.

Types of Elites in Contemporary India

Elite	Basis	Features
Political elite	Legislators, party leaders, ministers	Include dynasties, regional leaders and increasingly OBC, Dalit and women representatives; role of money and criminalisation in politics
Bureaucratic elite	IAS, IPS, IFS and other services	Steel frame legacy; expertise and authority; increasing diversity through reservation; interface with political and corporate elite
Economic / corporate elite	Business families, top executives, startup founders	Wealth concentration, lobbying and links with finance; global integration
Professional and intellectual elite	Lawyers, doctors, academics, scientists, media leaders	Cultural capital, expertise, English and global networks
Rural / regional elite	Dominant castes and rich peasants	Control of land, cooperatives, local politics, education institutions
Cultural and media elite	Film personalities, celebrity influencers, sports icons	Visibility and symbolic power; influence on values and consumption
Dalit-Bahujan elite	Politicians, civil servants, professionals, entrepreneurs from SC/ST/OBC groups	Product of reservation and mobilisation; example of Dalit Indian Chamber of Commerce and Industry (DICCI); tensions between community solidarity and individual mobility

= **What is "New" about the New Elite?**

- **Changing social base:** more mixed caste and regional backgrounds than the earlier upper-caste, English-educated elite, but still with strong upper-caste presence in business, media and academia.
- **Market and knowledge-based wealth:** entrepreneurs in IT, finance, e-commerce and startups; billionaire growth after 1991.

- **Globalised networks:** education abroad, diaspora connections and transnational consumption.
- **Political shift:** decline of the single-party dominance, rise of regional and identity-based leaders (the "second democratic upsurge" in Yogendra Yadav's phrase for the assertion of backward castes).
- **Media visibility:** social media and 24x7 news amplify the influence of celebrity and business elites.

Critical Perspectives

Critics argue that inequality has widened, with a sharp rise in the wealth share of the top 1 per cent (as documented in studies by Thomas Piketty, Lucas Chancel and others). Dipankar Gupta (Mistaken Modernity) argues that Indian elites failed to build broad-based capacities, while Ashis Nandy and others critique elite cultural values. Sociologists also study the reproduction of elite advantage through elite schools, social networks and inheritance, and the intersection of caste and class in these processes.

Identity and Ethnic Assertions

Identity refers to a sense of belonging to a group defined by caste, religion, language, region, tribe, gender or class. **Ethnicity** is a form of identity based on perceived shared descent, culture, language, territory or history. **Identity assertion** occurs when groups mobilise to claim recognition, rights, resources or autonomy. Fredrik Barth stressed that ethnic identity is created and maintained at group **boundaries**, while Paul Brass argues that elites often mobilise ethnic symbols for political gains (the instrumentalist view). Primordia lists such as Clifford Geertz stress deep emotional attachments to language, religion and kinship.

Types of Identity and Ethnic Assertions in India

Type	Examples	Main demands / features
Regional and sub-national	Dravidian movement and anti-Hindi agitations in Tamil Nadu (1937, 1965); Punjab; Assam movement (1979-85); Telangana	Cultural autonomy, protection of language, economic justice, statehood
Tribal (Adivasi)	Jharkhand, Bodoland, Naga and Mizo movements; Gorkhaland demand; Forest Rights Act 2006 mobilisations; PESA	Land, forest and resource rights, autonomy (Fifth and Sixth Schedules), cultural identity, resistance to displacement
Linguistic	Reorganisation of states 1956; Gujarat and Maharashtra (1960); Punjab (1966)	Recognition of languages, state formation; the Eighth Schedule
Caste-based	Dalit movements, OBC and Mandal politics (Mandal	Recognition, reservation, representation, dignity

Type	Examples	Main demands / features
	Commission 1980, implementation 1990), Maratha, Patidar and Jat reservation demands	
Religious and communal	Hindutva, Sikh, Muslim and Christian identity politics	Religious rights, representation, personal law debates, communal mobilisation
Gender and sexuality	Women's movement; LGBTQ+ movement; transgender rights (NALSA judgment 2014; Navtej Johar 2018)	Equality, safety, dignity, rights
Migrant and "sons of the soil"	Assam, Maharashtra, Northeast	Protection of local jobs and culture against in-migration

Causes of Ethnic and Identity Assertions

- **Uneven development and regional inequality:** perceived neglect fosters demands for autonomy.
- **Democratic politics:** electoral competition encourages mobilisation of identity and lets groups bargain for power.
- **Cultural insecurity:** fear of assimilation or domination by dominant language, religion or caste.
- **Displacement and resource conflict:** mining, dams and land acquisition affecting tribal and rural communities.
- **Education and awareness:** growth of a literate, politically conscious leadership within the group (Rajni Kothari, Paul Brass).
- **Colonial classification:** census and administrative categorisation hardened group boundaries.
- **Globalisation and media:** provide symbols, networks and platforms for identity politics, while also causing anxiety over cultural loss.

State Response and Constitutional Accommodation

India's federal and secular Constitution, the linguistic reorganisation of states, the Fifth and Sixth Schedules for tribal areas, reservations, minority rights (Articles 29-30) and special provisions for some states (e.g., Article 371 provisions for the Northeast) constitute a model of **accommodation of diversity**. Ashutosh Varshney has argued that civic engagement across communities reduces ethnic violence. At the same time, insurgencies, communal riots and secessionist movements have posed challenges; the state has responded with negotiation, accords (e.g., Mizo Accord 1986, Assam Accord 1985, Bodo agreements) and, at times, coercion. Amartya Sen (Identity and Violence) warns against reducing people to a single identity and stresses plural, chosen identities.

Skill Development and Employability Dimensions

Skill	How this unit develops it	Career relevance
Social stratification analysis	Using class, caste, gender and elite concepts to interpret data	Policy research, development consulting, civil services
Labour and livelihood awareness	Understanding informal work, unions, migration and gig work	HR and labour welfare, trade unions, labour departments, social security programmes
Market and consumer insight	Understanding middle-class values, aspirations and consumption	Market research, marketing, brand strategy, advertising
Rural development skills	Understanding agrarian classes, land, credit and cooperatives	NGOs, NABARD, rural banking, agricultural extension, CSR
Conflict resolution and inclusion	Analysis of ethnic and identity conflicts, negotiation and dialogue	Public administration, peacebuilding, community relations, diversity and inclusion roles
Data and survey skills	Working with NSSO/PLFS, Census, NFHS, Agricultural Census	Data analysis, monitoring and evaluation, research organisations
Communication and advocacy	Reasoned argumentation on sensitive issues	Media, law, politics, public policy

UNIT-III

LONG QUESTIONS

1. Discuss the development of class structure in India from the pre-colonial and colonial periods to contemporary India. Explain the role of colonial land systems and post-independence economic transformations.

2. Examine the agrarian class structure in India. Discuss landlords, rich and middle peasants, small and marginal farmers, tenants, agricultural labourers and rural non-farm classes with reference to changing rural relations.

3. Critically examine the relationship between caste and class in agrarian India. How have land ownership, dominant castes, migration, wage labour and occupational diversification changed traditional caste-class relations?

4. Discuss the emergence and transformation of the Indian middle class. Differentiate between the old middle class, new middle class and emerging neo-middle class and analyse their social, economic, cultural and political roles.

5. What is meant by the "new Indian elite"? Discuss the major types of contemporary elites and examine how caste, education, wealth, professional status, political power, global networks and media contribute to elite formation.

UNIT – IV

CASTE AND POLITICS

Meaning and Sociological Understanding of Caste

Caste is a system of social stratification in which social membership has historically been strongly associated with birth, endogamy, status hierarchy, customary occupations and ideas of social distance. The lived reality of caste varies across regions and communities, so caste should not be treated as a completely uniform institution.

G. S. Ghurye highlighted features such as segmental division, hierarchy, restrictions on social interaction, civil and religious disabilities, hereditary membership and restrictions on occupation. M. N. Srinivas examined processes such as Sanskritization and dominant caste, showing that caste changes through interaction with political power, education, economic mobility and local institutions.

B. R. Ambedkar approached caste primarily through inequality, graded hierarchy and the denial of social fraternity. For Ambedkar, political democracy could not be secure without social democracy. Contemporary scholarship also treats caste as multidimensional, connected with cultural, economic, political, ideological, class and gender relations.

Caste and Political Mobilisation

Democracy has not simply eliminated caste; it has created new arenas in which caste identities can be organised, negotiated and represented. Elections, parties, pressure groups, associations and social movements can make caste a basis of collective political action.

- Caste associations can articulate demands for education, employment, representation and public resources.
- Political parties may mobilise communities through social coalitions and candidate selection.
- Reservations and affirmative action make social categories relevant to public policy and political debate.
- Local government can provide opportunities for representation and leadership among historically excluded groups.
- Caste-based mobilisation may produce political voices, but it can also encourage competition among communities and identity-based polarization.

Caste as a Political Resource

Political sociology distinguishes between caste as a traditional social hierarchy and caste as a modern political resource. A group that was historically disadvantaged may use collective identity to demand recognition and redistribution. At the same time, dominant groups may mobilise to protect status or perceived access to resources. Thus, caste politics cannot be understood only as backward-looking; it can also be a language of democratic bargaining.

Important Concepts

- Dominant caste: a locally influential caste combining numerical strength, land/economic resources and political influence.

- Vote-bank politics: a term used to describe organised electoral support associated with a social group; the term is contested and should be used carefully.
- Identity politics: political mobilization around a shared social identity and associated interests.
- Affirmative action: measures designed to improve representation and opportunity for groups facing historical or structural disadvantages.

CASTE AND POLITICS

Caste, Reservation and Social Justice

The Indian Constitution prohibits discrimination on specified grounds and provides a framework for equality and special provisions for disadvantaged groups. Article 15 prohibits discrimination on grounds including religion, race, caste and sex, while permitting specified special provisions; Article 16 establishes equality of opportunity in public employment and permits constitutionally authorised provisions relating to backward classes and representation.

The constitutional approach reflects the tension between formal equality and substantive equality. Formal equality means treating citizens according to the same general legal standard. Substantive equality recognises that historical disadvantage may require targeted measures to create meaningful equality of opportunity.

Positive Functions of Caste Politics

- Creates political visibility for historically excluded groups.
- Encourages leadership development and participation in democratic institutions.
- Places questions of representation, dignity and social justice on the public agenda.
- Can strengthen bargaining power in relation to education, employment and welfare.

Problems and Limitations

- Fragmentation of political communities into competing identity blocks.
- Possibility of elite capture, where better-positioned members receive a larger share of benefits.
- Reduction of complex economic and social interests to cast identity alone.
- Political mobilisation may reproduce stereotypes rather than weaken them.
- Competition over public resources can intensify tensions between groups.

Caste and Social Change

Modernisation, urbanisation, education, migration and occupational mobility have weakened some traditional caste restrictions, but they have not automatically removed caste consciousness. Caste can persist in marriage, social networks, political mobilisation, access to resources and experiences of discrimination. Therefore, the sociological question is not simply whether caste has disappeared, but how its forms and functions have changed.

DALIT CONSCIOUSNESS

Meaning

The term ‘Dalit’ is associated with experiences of oppression, exclusion and historical caste-based subordination, but it is also used as a political and emancipatory identity. Dalit consciousness refers to a critical awareness of caste oppression, dignity, rights and collective agency. It is not simply awareness of being disadvantaged; it involves questioning the social structures and cultural ideas that legitimise inequality.

Ambedkar and the Intellectual Foundations

Dr. B. R. Ambedkar is central to the development of modern Dalit consciousness. His analysis linked caste to social hierarchy, exclusion and denial of equal citizenship. He

emphasised education, organisation and collective struggle, and argued for a social order based on liberty, equality and fraternity.
Ambedkar's critique of caste was not limited to economic deprivation. It addressed status, dignity, social interaction, access to public spaces and the ideological legitimation of hierarchy. Contemporary scholarship continues to discuss his idea of annihilating caste as both structural transformation and transformation of consciousness.

Major Sources of Dalit Consciousness

1. Education: Literacy and higher education create access to knowledge, institutions and professional mobility.
2. Collective organisation: Associations, movements and political organisations convert individual experiences into collective demands.
3. Political representation: Participation in legislatures, local government and public institutions provides avenues for voice.
4. Literature and culture: Dalit autobiographies, poetry, theatre and art challenge dominant representations and make lived experience visible.
5. Legal consciousness: Awareness of constitutional rights and protective laws can strengthen the capacity to challenge discrimination.
6. Alternative religious and ethical identities: Ambedkar's turn to Buddhism is an important example of re-imagining dignity and community.

Dalit Literature and Cultural Assertion

Dalit literature has contributed to consciousness by placing experience at the centre of knowledge. Autobiographical writing often documents humiliation, exclusion, labour, resistance and aspiration. The cultural sphere therefore becomes a site of contesting whose experiences count as socially legitimate knowledge.

Dalit Movements

Dalit mobilisation has included social reform, educational movements, political organisations, cultural assertion, legal activism and demands for representation. Its forms have differed by region and period. Scholarship on Dalit politics notes substantial changes in the movement's strategies and political contexts over the decades after independence.

Ambedkarization

'Ambedkarization' is used in sociological and political studies to describe the spread of Ambedkar's ideas, symbols and practices among Dalit communities. Research from Uttar Pradesh has examined how Ambedkarite identity can influence social mobility, religious practice and political consciousness.

Key Dimensions

- Self-respect: rejection of practices and beliefs that normalise humiliation.
- Rights consciousness: understanding equality, representation and legal protections.
- Collective identity: development of solidarity around shared experiences and aspirations.
- Political agency: participation in institutions rather than remaining objects of policy.
- Cultural agency: production of alternative narratives, symbols and histories.
- Economic mobility: education, entrepreneurship, occupational change and access to secure employment.

Legal and Institutional Measures

The Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955 addresses the enforcement and practice of untouchability-related disabilities. The Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989 provides a legal framework concerning atrocities, special courts and rights of victims and witnesses.

Critical Issues

- Legal rights may exist without equal access to justice because of social and institutional barriers.
- Educational mobility can coexist with discrimination in institutions and labour markets.
- Dalit communities are internally diverse by region, occupation, gender, class and political orientation.
- Dalit women may experience overlapping caste and gender inequalities; therefore, a gender-sensitive analysis is essential.
- Digital spaces create new opportunities for mobilisation but may also reproduce abuse and exclusion.

COMMUNALISM

Meaning

Communalism is a sociological and political process in which religious identity becomes the primary basis for defining social groups, interests and political conflict. Religion itself is not communalism. Individuals may possess strong religious identities without treating other religious communities as political enemies.

Religion versus Communalism

Religion may provide belief, ritual, ethics, community and meaning. Communalism emerges when religious differences are interpreted through competitive group identities and political interests. Thus, the study of communalism requires attention to institutions, historical narratives, economic competition, political mobilisation and media.

Forms of Communalism

- Everyday prejudice: stereotypes, social distance and suspicion towards another religious community.
- Communal consciousness: perception that the interests of one religious community are fundamentally different from those of another.
- Political mobilisation: use of religious identity to organise political support.
- Communal conflict: escalation into collective violence, intimidation, displacement or destruction of property.
- Institutional and symbolic dimensions: disputes over representation, public symbols, historical memory or access to spaces.

Communalism in Contemporary Society

Globalisation, migration, urbanisation and digital communication have created new forms of interaction among religious communities. Social media can facilitate dialogue and cultural exchange, but it can also rapidly circulate rumours, stereotypes and inflammatory content. Sociological analysis should therefore examine both technology and the institutions through which information is verified.

Role of Political Institutions

Democratic institutions can reduce communal conflict by protecting equal citizenship, enforcing law impartially, enabling representation and creating mechanisms for peaceful dispute resolution. Conversely, exclusionary political rhetoric or unequal institutional responses may deepen distrust.

Role of Education

- Promotes constitutional values and critical thinking.
- Encourages students to distinguish evidence from stereotypes and rumours.
- Introduces multiple perspectives on history and society.
- Creates opportunities for meaningful inter-group interaction.

Role of Civil Society

Civil society organisations, community groups, universities, professional bodies and local initiatives can build trust through dialogue, relief work, peace education and joint community programmes.

Communalism and Secularism

Indian secularism can be studied as a constitutional principle involving freedom of conscience and religion, equality before law and a state framework that does not establish a theocratic political order. Secularism does not mean absence of religion from society; rather, it concerns the relationship between religion, citizenship and public institutions.

RELIGIOUS REVIVALISM

Meaning

Religious revivalism refers to a renewed emphasis on religious beliefs, practices, institutions, symbols or traditions. Revivalism may involve reform, return to perceived authentic traditions, cultural reconstruction, missionary activity, identity formation or political mobilisation. It is therefore a broader category than communalism.

Revivalism, Reform and Fundamentalism

Religious revivalism may overlap with reform movements, but reform seeks to reinterpret or change practices whereas revivalism often emphasises recovery or renewed commitment to traditions. Fundamentalism is a more specific term generally associated with strong claims about authoritative religious texts or doctrines and resistance to perceived secular or modern reinterpretation. The concepts should not be used interchangeably.

Social Conditions Behind Revivalism

- Rapid social change and uncertainty can create demand for cultural continuity.
- Modernisation may produce a search for identity and belonging.
- Migration and diaspora experiences can strengthen symbolic attachment to religion.
- Political competition may make religious identity more visible.
- Social inequality and perceived cultural marginalisation may encourage collective mobilisation.
- Mass media and digital platforms can intensify the circulation of religious symbols and narratives.

Theoretical Perspectives

Durkheim

Émile Durkheim viewed religion as a source of social solidarity and collective representations. Rituals create collective effervescence and reinforce group membership.

Weber

Max Weber examined religion in relation to meaning, authority, ethics and social action. Religious ideas can influence economic and political behaviour.

Marx

Karl Marx analysed religion in relation to social conditions, alienation and power. His approach encourages sociologists to ask how religious ideas interact with material inequalities and institutions.

Contemporary Approach

Contemporary sociology studies revivalism through identity, nationalism, gender, media, migration, globalisation and political economy. Revivalist movements may contain both emancipatory and exclusionary tendencies depending on context; these should be examined empirically rather than assumed.

Indian Context

India has experienced multiple religious reform and revival movements across different traditions. These movements have contributed variously to social reform, education, cultural identity and political mobilisation. Their sociological study requires attention to historical period, social class, caste, gender and region.

RELIGIOUS REVIVALISM

Revivalism and Identity

Identity is relational: people define themselves partly through distinctions from others. Revivalist movements can create strong community bonds by emphasising shared history, symbols, festivals, texts and practices. Such identity can provide social support and cultural confidence. However, when identity becomes exclusive, it may produce boundaries between insiders and outsiders.

Revivalism and Modernity

It is misleading to assume that modernisation necessarily destroys religion. Modern education, urbanisation and technology can coexist with renewed religious participation. Digital platforms may allow religious communities to build translocal networks, disseminate teachings and organise events.

Gender and Revivalism

Women can be both participants and leaders in religious revival movements. At the same time, revivalist discourse may influence expectations about family, dress, sexuality, work and gender roles. A sociological analysis should therefore ask: Who defines tradition? Whose interpretation becomes authoritative? How are women's choices affected? Are women gaining organisational agency or facing greater regulation?

Revivalism and Politics

Religious revivalism becomes politically significant when religious symbols, institutions or narratives are connected to state power, electoral mobilisation, citizenship debates or public policy. Sociology should distinguish religious participation from political mobilisation and should examine specific evidence rather than making general assumptions.

Positive and Negative Possibilities

- Possible constructive dimensions: cultural preservation, community solidarity, charity, education, social service and moral engagement.
- Possible risks: exclusionary identity boundaries, intolerance, stereotyping, politicisation of faith and conflict.
- The same movement may have different effects across social groups; class, caste and gender should therefore be included in analysis.

PROBLEMS OF MINORITIES

Meaning of Minority

A minority is not simply a group smaller in numerical size. Sociologically, minority status may involve unequal power, social visibility, cultural distinctiveness, discrimination or limited representation. A group can be numerically large in one region and a minority in another. Therefore, context matters.

Constitutional Framework

The Constitution provides protections concerning equality, freedom of religion and cultural and educational rights. Article 29 addresses protection of interests of sections of citizens with a distinct language, script or culture, while Article 30 concerns the right of religious and linguistic minorities to establish and administer educational institutions of their choice.
The National Commission for Minorities Act, 1992 established the National Commission for Minorities and defines 'minority' for that Act as a community notified by the Central Government. The Central Government notified Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists and Parsis in 1993 for the purposes of the Act.

Minority Rights versus Equality

Minority rights are not necessarily opposed to equality. Equality can require recognition of cultural and institutional differences where equal citizenship would otherwise be weakened. The sociological issue is how to balance individual rights, group rights and constitutional principles.

. PROBLEMS OF MINORITIES

Institutional Responses

- Constitutional guarantees of equality, religious freedom and cultural/educational rights.
- National and state-level minority commissions and grievance mechanisms.
- Educational and welfare schemes aimed at improving access and opportunity.
- Scholarships, hostels, skill development and entrepreneurship support.
- Legal remedies against discrimination and violence.
- Community-based and civil-society interventions promoting education, livelihoods and social cohesion.

Sociological Approach to Minority Problems

A sociologist should avoid explaining minority disadvantage only through culture. Problems can arise from structural inequalities in education, labour markets, housing, political representation and access to institutions. At the same time, internal community differences matter: class, gender, region, age, rural–urban location and educational level may produce very different experiences within the same minority.

Integration, Assimilation and Pluralism

Assimilation suggests incorporation into a dominant cultural pattern. Integration suggests participation in common institutions while retaining aspects of cultural identity. Pluralism recognises the legitimacy of multiple cultural identities within a shared political framework. These concepts provide different ways to discuss minority-majority relations.

Challenges in Policy

- Targeted policies must reach intended beneficiaries rather than only better-connected groups.
- Group-level statistics can conceal large internal inequalities.
- Development programmes need both access and quality—mere enrolment does not guarantee outcomes.
- Skill programmes should connect training with actual labour-market demand and placement.
- Trust between institutions and communities is essential for effective implementation.

EMPOWERMENT OF WOMEN FOR SKILL DEVELOPMENT AND EMPLOYABILITY

Meaning of Women's Empowerment

Women's empowerment refers to expanding women's capacity to make choices, access resources, exercise agency and participate equally in social, economic and political life. Empowerment is broader than employment. A woman may be employed but still lack control over income, mobility, workplace safety or career decisions.

Skill Development

Skill development includes technical skills, vocational skills, digital skills, communication, financial literacy, entrepreneurship and problem-solving. For employability, skills need to be connected with labour-market demand, workplace behaviour, access to technology, networks and opportunities for practical experience.

Why Skill Development Matters

- Increases access to wage employment and self-employment.
- Improves confidence and bargaining power.
- Can increase household income and economic security.
- Supports entrepreneurship and digital participation.
- Expands occupational choices beyond traditionally gendered occupations.
- Improves the capacity to adapt to technological and economic change.

Barriers to Women's Employability

- Care responsibilities and unequal division of unpaid domestic work.
- Limited mobility and concerns about safe transport.
- Social norms restricting occupational choices.
- Unequal access to digital devices, internet and technology.
- Skills mismatch between training and available jobs.
- Limited access to finance, markets and business networks.
- Workplace discrimination and sexual harassment.
- Career interruptions due to marriage, childbirth or caregiving.
- Informal employment and lack of social protection.
- Intersectional barriers related to caste, class, disability, religion, location and age.

Skill Development and the Labour Market

Training is most effective when it connects mobilisation, counselling, skill training, certification, placement and post-placement support. The Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship has explicitly identified the need to connect trained women with wage employment and entrepreneurship, including training in non-traditional job roles.

WOMEN'S EMPOWERMENT

Women and Labour Force Participation

Labour force participation is an important indicator, but it should not be treated as the sole measure of empowerment. Quality of work, wages, security, working conditions, decision-making power and continuity of employment also matter. India's PLFS 2023–24 reported that female LFPR for persons aged 15 years and above in usual status increased to 41.7% at the all-India level, up from 23.3% in 2017–18. The 2024 PLFS indicators also reported changes in urban female participation and unemployment.

Women's Skill Development: Major Areas

- Digital literacy: office software, online communication, e-commerce, digital payments and cyber safety.
- Communication and professional skills: English/Hindi communication, presentation, interview skills and workplace etiquette.
- Technical skills: healthcare, electronics, IT, renewable energy, manufacturing, logistics and other demand-linked fields.
- Entrepreneurial skills: business planning, bookkeeping, marketing, customer management and digital commerce.
- Financial skills: savings, credit, insurance, basic taxation and responsible borrowing.
- Green and emerging skills: energy efficiency, sustainable production, electric mobility services and digital technologies.

From Training to Employability

Employability can be represented as a chain: Awareness → Counselling → Skill Training → Certification → Internship/Apprenticeship → Placement or Enterprise → Mentoring → Career Progression. If any link is weak, training may not translate into sustainable employment.

Empowerment and Intersectionality

A universal women's empowerment strategy may miss differences among women. Rural women, urban women, women from disadvantaged caste or minority communities, women with disabilities and women from low-income households may face different barriers. Intersectionality therefore helps identify multiple and overlapping sources of disadvantage.

UNIT-IV

LONG QUESTIONS

1. Discuss caste as a system of social stratification and examine its major sociological features. Compare the approaches of G.S. Ghurye, M.N. Srinivas and B.R. Ambedkar towards understanding caste.

2. Critically examine the relationship between caste and political mobilisation in contemporary India. How have elections, political parties, caste associations, reservations and social movements transformed caste into a political resource?

3. Explain the concept of "dominant caste" given by M.N. Srinivas. Discuss the relationship between numerical strength, land ownership, economic resources and political influence in the formation of dominant castes.

4. Discuss caste, reservation and social justice in India. Examine the tension between formal equality and substantive equality and analyse the positive functions as well as limitations of caste-based political mobilisation.

5. Explain the concept of Dalit consciousness. Discuss B.R. Ambedkar's contribution and examine the role of education, collective organisation, political representation, literature, legal consciousness and alternative identities in the development of Dalit consciousness.